

INTL 511/601: International Relations Theory Midterm Exam

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Section 1: Short Answer Questions (20%)

1. Realism in Donnelly: "According to Jack Donnelly's discussion of Realism, how does Kenneth Waltz's structural realism differ from classical realism?"

Answer: The main difference is that neorealism by Waltz's mainly looks at the international system rather than human nature.

2. Liberal Internationalism: "What are the core tenets of Liberal Internationalism post-Cold War, as outlined by Burchill?"

Answer: The cornerstone of liberal internationalism was a strong belief in international institutions with the promotion of liberal democracy—additionally, a focus on economic globalization and the inherent belief to fight for human rights.

3. Critical Theory by Linklater: "What role does the 'politics of knowledge' play in shaping IR according to Linklater?"

Answer: The understanding of the politics of knowledge by Linklater reads that in international relations knowledge is produced and consumed considering the influence of the power structure and normative practices. With this, he highlights that critical theories aim is to uncover the difficulties and the one-sided biases that are in mainstream theories which helps them maintain things as they are. With that, critical theory will be able to empower marginalized voices and free people from the global political community.

4. Constructivism in Reus-Smit: "According to Reus-Smit, how does anarchy differ based on social interactions and shared norms? Provide a quote from the assigned readings to support your answer."

Answer: Christian Reus-Smit argues that anarchy is not static, but socially constructed through relations between states and the internalization of norms. He claims that how states

understand and respond to anarchy is shaped by cultural, historical and normative frameworks specific to each state interaction. As Reus-Smit is fond of pointing out, "Anarchy is what states make of it," i.e., the qualities of the international system are socially constructed more than conflictual.

Section 2: Analytical Essays (50%)

- Purpose: To evaluate the depth of analysis and theoretical integration.

Choose one of the following essay topics (5-6 Pages).

1. Prompt 1: "Compare how Marxism and Critical Theory approach global capitalism.

Include arguments from Griffiths, and discuss the influence of global capitalism."

Answer:

Today, the international landscape is increasingly shaped by global capitalism — a market-based framework organized around transnational production networks, financial markets, and deepening inequalities. This type of system has been heavily critiqued through theoretical perspectives like Marxism and Critical Theory. Marxism explores the exploitative and oppressive mechanisms at play in capitalism, looking to the revolutionary power of class, specifically that of the exploited proletariat; Critical Theory takes a wider lens. In this essay I compare these perspectives, outlining their main arguments and their readings of capitalism's role while also weaving Griffiths' insights in wherever appropriate.

Marxism, rooted in the works of Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, critiques capitalism as a historically contingent system defined by exploitation and class conflict. Global capitalism, for Marxists, represents an advanced stage in the historical progression of modes of production. That drive, Marxists argue, will lead capitalism to expand across the globe in search of new areas to extract profit from and places to sell its goods. The expansion of

capitalism is explained by historical materialism in that societies are constantly being made to fit capitalist modes of production. Prompted by the connection of global capitalism and imperialism, Marxism depicts advanced capitalist states as reproducing conditions of exploitation that place weaker nations in a permanent state of economic dependency and underdevelopment.

Griffiths indicates the institutionalization of economic inequality in this global capitalist system is said to give rise to what neo-Marxists refer to as a "core-periphery" dynamic. This scenario, also known as unequal development, is rooted in the structure of capitalism itself where core nations dominate over peripheral by extracting resources and labour creating centres of hegemony with peripheral regions being pushed out of the global economy gaining a centre-margin dynamic. This interaction reveals the structural inequalities embodied in globalization, rendering it a "dialectic of opportunity and exploitation"(Burchill).

As a principle of Marxist theory, class struggle is said to be the most powerful moving force in society transformation. In a globalizing world, this struggle also becomes essential. In this case, class divisions become more distinct, and the proletariat faces isolation and capitalistic exploitation. The Marxists claim that globalization is a factor which creates the unity of the oppressed people's classes beyond the borders, thus, fostering the conditions for revolutionary developments and world peace. Yet, Griffiths shows their weakness by stating this too deterministic since any class consciousness does not appear to be formed in a coherent way throughout the world's diverse space(Burchill)(Burchill).

Building upon this, neomarxist thinkers such as Antonio Gramsci in fact go further in making the case of culture and ideology in supremacy. They contended it was the global capitalist structures that achieved hegemony not by the means of providing resources alone but by redefining the social culture and values that were geared towards justifying its existence. This

elaboration cannot be missed due to overlap with Critical Theory which comes later in discussion, but still retains the Marxist blind spot which considers the class-struggle view of the world as comprehensive for explaining international relations.

Critical Theory accepts that global capitalism is exploitative, however places Marxism as being too narrowly focused on material conditions and economic exploitation. Instead, Critical Theory studies how cultural (ideological) systems are structured by capitalism so that domination can be ordered. The mass media and consumer culture Horkheimer and Adorno refer to as "the culture industry transmute[s] into a single, all-destroying force the tailored and for good purposes intentions of aesthetic mimesis" while creating passive consumption habits, which guides attention away from issues of systemic inequality *A Drunk With Bad Dreams*(Burchill).

Taking this critique one step further, Griffiths asserts that global capitalism does not merely justify the economic exploitation of poorer countries but also prides itself on endlessly commodifying cultural identities and norms. For example, worldwide swinging media multidisciplinary spread a standard culture - the dominance of the West is confirmed and diverse voices are excluded and intimidated(Burchill).

While Marxism limits revolutionary potential to the proletariat, Critical Theory has a wider understanding of emancipation. For Jürgen Habermas his emphasis on communicative action promotes democratic and participatory structures that effectively empower marginalized groups. This perspective criticizes the instrumental rationality of capitalism which emphasizes efficiency and profits over ethics and social relations.

Over against the alleged universality of Marxist emancipatory goals, Critical Theory, drawing from Continental philosophy particularly as well as postmodern insights (though claiming to be neither), explicitly challenges such generalizations, basing its argument on multiple

historical and social peculiarities. To this end Griffiths emphasised that global solidarity has to embrace different forms of liberation and not only one revolutionary possibility(Burchill) (Burchill).

Habermas' reconstruction of historical materialism combines Marxism with Critical Theory, by establishing a relationship between economic structures and communicative forms. Read with one another, this body of work offers an important critique of global capitalism that is simultaneously material and ideational. Because it connects systemic domination with cultural and ideological processes, Critical Theory also provides a richer critique of global capitalism than traditional Marxism.

Global capitalism itself is inherently exploitative, making global inequalities worse from a Marxist perspective. The profit over human welfare logic of its structural set-up, and the recurrent crises in which such existence is based keep creating events revolving around misery at the peripheral which fills the self devouring beast seemingly struggling with its own so-called instinct for survival. But it also lays the groundwork for revolution, revealing ever more clearly the contradictions of capitalism. Capitalist societies, they argue, do not just exploit economically — capitalism has a broader cultural and ideological influence that embeds itself in societal norms and values. Above all, they call for participatory frameworks that address inequalities beyond class alone and reflect dimensions of gender, race, and the environment. While Marxism offers a structural analysis of capitalism's global operations, Critical Theory provides a broader critique that incorporates cultural and communicative dimensions. Both perspectives are essential for understanding the multifaceted nature of global capitalism and its impact on societies worldwide.

Marxism and Critical Theory present complementary critiques of global capitalism, each addressing distinct dimensions of its impact. Marxism offers a structural analysis that

highlights class struggle and systemic exploitation, while Critical Theory investigates the cultural and ideological mechanisms that uphold capitalist hegemony. Integrating these perspectives allows for a deeper understanding of global capitalism, emphasizing the need for multifaceted approaches to tackle its pervasive influence. As Griffiths points out, the challenge lies in striking a balance between revolutionary aspirations and practical efforts to cultivate global solidarity and inclusive emancipation (Burchill).

Section 3: Simulation Exercise (20%)

- Purpose: Acclimate to applying IR theories in practical contexts.

Scenario: Analyze a territorial dispute using one IR theory; describe motivations, actions, outcomes. Include relevant quotes from assigned readings to support your analysis.

- Expected Outcome: A 2-3 page analysis applying chosen theory to crisis.

Applying Realism to a Territorial Dispute: The South China Sea Crisis

Realism, one of the most enduring theories in International Relations (IR), provides a pragmatic lens to analyze territorial disputes. Its focus on power, security, and state interests in an anarchic international system makes it particularly suited for understanding the ongoing territorial contestation in the South China Sea. This region, marked by strategic importance, abundant natural resources, and geopolitical tensions, is a case study in how states behave in pursuit of power and security under conditions of anarchy. Drawing on key realist concepts and supported by relevant scholarly insights, this essay explores the motivations, actions, and likely outcomes of states involved in the South China Sea dispute, particularly emphasizing China's role.

First, realism is based on the belief that the order in international relations is anarchic and lacks a higher authority to ensure state regulation. Such a condition leads to the self-help behaviour of states, whose first objective is survival and security. Classical realism, as expressed by theorists like Hans Morgenthau, sees an underlying drive for power as part of the very nature of humanity and one important source of conflict. On the contrary, structural realism or neorealism represented by Kenneth Waltz refocuses attention on the structure of the international system and how its distribution of power creates a logic of competition among states for relative gains and security. In analysing this crisis it is important to look at it from the cornerstone of these three tenants of realism, the anarchic nature of the international landscape makes it so that there is an overarching central authority which then makes it so that states are overly suspicious of each other. Secondly, every state in the international landscape looks to maximize its power to get ahead of the others, this can then be done either internally with economic and military build-up or externally with alliances and gaining a territorial advantage. Finally, every state in the states seeks to act and pursue things in its national interest which are normally categorized by power or security. With the application of these three principles, it will be to understand how realism elucidates the motivation and actions of key actors.

Background

The South China Sea is one of the most strategic and economically significant regions in the world. Control of this area offers significant economic benefits, with an estimated 11 billion barrels of oil, 190 trillion cubic feet of natural gas, and large fishing resources to be exploited. In addition, it also goes through much shipping — fully one-third of all global shipping passes through its waters. To paraphrase a famous line from previous decades, China claiming dominion over the South China Sea follows multiple venerable realist pursuits.

Then first things, security issues are a top priority. For China, control over the South China Sea is a way to safeguard its southern flank against hegemonic powers—most importantly the United States—that might try to blockade Chinese ports. Theory of Realism highlights that states strive to limit vulnerabilities, ensuring China militarizes artificial islands in order to prevent possible adversaries and protect its surrounding waters.

Second, China wants hegemony. China, a rising power that wants to be the preeminent actor in the Asia-Pacific, claiming sovereignty over the "Nine-Dash Line" — a demarcation line that covers nearly all of the South China Sea — is an effort by China to exercise its "sphere of influence" and push power dynamics in Asia into a form where it will have more advantage. As Kenneth Waltz argues: “states are compelled by the logic that the structure of international system imposes on them to balance or pursue regional hegemony”, elaborate this applies well to China's strategy (Burchill).

Finally, the economic interest. The South China Sea provides a plethora of resources, control over which enhances China's energy security and economic development — both necessary for sustaining stable political conditions at home and underpinning its long-term global ambitions.

The main realism principles were very much evident in the following actions China took. To start with, China constructed military bases, airstrips, ports, and sort of strategic outposts showing as a sign of power projection in the South China Sea. As per realism: As China rejected the 2016 Permanent Court of Arbitration ruling, which declared invalid Chinese territorial claims, but instead its validity as a constituent of world law. According to Morgenthau "The standards of International law and morality quickly yield to the pressure of national interest"(Burchill). Finally, China does not want multilateral negotiations but prefers

bilateral ones, where it can use its superior weight against smaller claimant states such as Vietnam or the Philippines.

Claimant states besides China, such as Vietnam, the Philippines, and Malaysia have employed some combination of balancing strategy and bandwagoning strategy. Vietnam has built closer relations with outside powers, particularly the US in an effort to thwart Chinese misbehaviour while smaller states tend to merit material rewards by complying or acceding to Asian vis-223-vis elite demands. The realist nature of balancing, and accommodation in an anarchic system is evident from these responses.

The realist viewpoint views the legal dispute between the Philippines and China over some regions in the South China Sea as a futile effort. Other and more effective means will be employed to settle the disputes instead of legal processes. The balance and power of the states that are part of the dispute will present various options in resolving the issue. There are three outcomes that fit the description of realist theories: They would act according to the principle of maximum security as all states in the region are at an arms buildup stage. Without efforts to contain China's actions, the country's grip over the South China Sea will strengthen its position in the region. This is consistent with the neo-realist view advanced by Waltz who propounded that a global superpower must hold regional dominance (Burchill). The intersection of these countries' interests finds its most potent expression in the South China Sea. The realism theory sees this development as a situation where these two major states become a threat to each other. As Donnelly notes, "In an anarchic system, states will always pursue power and security since these two are the primary core focuses" (Burchill).

The South China Sea dispute is a real-life case that explains the basic ideas of realism. Through the eyes of China, which has provocative behavior based on security needs, economic ambitions, and the urge for hegemony, realism has an emphasis on power and

survival. The actions of the other claimant state and the role of the external powers amplify the already existing nature of a system without a ruler which is competitive and conflict prone. The second of the two theories, realism, offers a chilling view that suggests the settlement of the dispute will not be brought about by legal or moral means but by a change in the balance of power in the region. The very words of Hans Morgenthau "The power struggle is omnipresent and unavoidable" prove the reality, which is shown vividly through the case of the South China Sea crisis.

Section 4: Synthesis and Reflection (10%)

- Purpose: To synthesize perspectives and reflect critically.

Question: "How do Waltz's structural realism and Reus-Smit's Constructivism differ on anarchy? Provide specific references from the readings to support your answer."

Anarchy in international relations is the absence of overall authority that states can be answerable to. Kenneth Waltz's structuralism and Christian Reus Smith's constructivism provide us with different interpretations of this concept. In Waltz's view what determines the effect of anarchy is state behavior, whereas Reus Smith looks at it as how social norms form its meaning and implications.

Waltz's structural realism looks at anarchy in the light of it being the main feature of the international system, which influences how states behave. He views anarchy as a constraint that makes states strive for survival and consequently act rationally with a self-help system. His principles are that anarchy brings competition in the international system as states look to survive relying on their capability to ensure security. Secondly, Waltz internationally deviate from any social dimensions in his analysis of anarchy, from which he tries to assert that the anarchic nature of states is permanent. It shapes their ideas and actions regardless of their

domestic characteristics. Finally, the fixed assumption by Waltz enables him to create certain frameworks for forecasting state behavior based on power balance.

Reus-Smit's constructivism challenges the idea that anarchy universally constrains state behavior. Instead, it sees anarchy as a socially constructed phenomenon shaped by shared norms and practices. He argues that anarchy does not inherently dictate how states act; rather, its impact depends on states' interpretations and interactions. Building on Wendt's assertion that "anarchy is what states make of it," Reus-Smit emphasizes the roles of culture and history in shaping international relations. States' identities influence their views on anarchy—liberal democracies may see it as a realm for cooperation, while authoritarian regimes might view it as conflict-prone. Unlike Waltz, Reus-Smit sees anarchy as fluid and evolving, allowing constructivism to account for variations in state behavior across different historical and cultural contexts.

The key differences highlighted by the two in terms of anarchy are in the context of the nature of anarchy, Waltz, sees it as fixed with features that make it possible for states to produce predictable outcomes. However, Reus-Smith portrays it as dynamic and socially constructed strongly influenced by norms, identities, and interactions. Furthermore, they differ in their focus of analysis as Waltz upholds the belief of the system's material structure like the distribution of power as the main determinant to state behaviour. Reus-Smith on the other hand, focuses on ideational factors in shaping how states go through anarchy. Finally, Waltz predicts uniform behaviour among states, with the need to survive in an anarchic system. As Reus-Smith portrays the diversity of state responses to anarchy, is driven by cultural and historical contexts.

There are essentially two opposite perspectives on the real nature of anarchic international relations which are represented by Waltz's structural realism and Reus-Smit's constructivism.

According to Waltz, the view of the world is static and materialist, and, therefore, anarchy is perceived as a universal imperative that sets the rules of the states' game. In contrast to this, Reus-Smit's constructivism regards anarchy as an energetic and flexible concept that can be created by social norms and interactions. These distinctions point out the larger theoretical chasms between realism and constructivism, the former being a systemic determinism and the latter being a theory which stresses human agency and social structures. These approaches thus help in international relations not only by exhibiting the immutability but also the changes in state behavior considering the anarchic world.